BEST PERFORMER digit SEPTEMBER 2008

BEST BUY digit SEPTEMBER 2008

Digicams - Above Rs 16,001

BRAND MODEL NO	Canon Digital IXUS 85 IS	Canon Digital IXUS 960 IS	Olympus Stylus 1030 SW	Samsung NV24HD
Price (Rs)	16,995	24,995	20,995	19,990
Plus (+)	Excellent value for money	Good performance	Tough build	720p video capturing
Minus (-)	No manual focus	Expensive	Average looks	Average performance
Grand Total (Out of 100)	61.27	61.10	57.05	58.83
Features (Out of 25)	16.21	15.84	15.76	16.85
Design (Out of 10)	5.25	5.45	7.00	5.90
Performance (Out of 65)	39.81	39.81	34.29	36.08
Features				
CCD Sensor (Megapixels)	10	12.1	10.1	10.2
Maximum Image Resolution	3648 x 2736	4000 x 3000	3648 x 2736	3648 x 2736
Sensor Size	1/2.3”	1/1.7”	1/2.35”	1/2.3”
Optical Zoom	3x	3.7x	3.6x	3.6x
Digital Zoom	4x	4x	5x	5x
Autofocus	✔	✔	✔	✔
Manual Focus	✘	✘	✘	✘
Macro Focus Range (cm)	3	5	2	5
LCD Viewfinder Size (Inches)	2.5	2.5	2.7	2.5
LCD Viewfinder Resolution (pixels)	230000	230000	230000	230000
Dimensions (w x h x d) cms	8.6 x 5.4 x 2.0	9.59 x 5.99 x 2.76	9.36 x 6.09 x 2.13	9.85 x 6.1 x 1.89
Weight (gm)	130	165	170	145.5
ISO Setting	80 - 1600	80 - 1600	80 - 1600	80 - 3200
White Balance Settings (✔/✘)/ No of settings/Custom white balance	✔, 5	✔, 5	✔, 6	✔, 5
Shutter Speed Range (Min - Manual, Max - Auto)	15 - 1/1500	15 - 1/1600	4 to 1/1000	16 - 1/2000
Metering Modes	3	3	2	3
Self-Timer (If Yes time in sec)	✔, 2, 10	✔, 2, 10	✔, 12	✔, 2,10
Integrated Flash/ Ext Flash support (✔/✘)	✔/✘	✔/✘	✔/✘	✔/✘
Memory Types Supported	SD/SDHC/MMC/ MMCPlus/HC MMCPlus	SD/SDHC/MMC/ MMCPlus/HC MMCPlus	XD, microSD	SD/MMC/SDHC
In-built Memory (MB)	32 (card)	32 (card)	14.7	16
Audio/Video-out	✔	✔	✔	✔, HDMI?
PC Interface	USB	USB	USB	USB
Best Video Capture Resolution	640 x 480, 30	1024x768, 15	640x480, 30	1280x720, 30
Battery Form Factor (If applicable)	Li-ion	Li-ion	Li-ion	Li-ion
Battery Charger Included	✔	✔	✔	✔
Face Detection	✔	✔	✔	✔
Image Stabilization	✔	✔	✔	✔
Design (Out of 10)				
Comfortable To Hold	5.5	5.5	7	6
Menu Navigation Ease	5.5	5.5	7	6
Button Ergonomicity	5	5	7	6.5
Build Quality Of body	5.5	6	7	5.5
Build Quality Of movable parts (Memory & battery mechanism, Lens/USB Door)	4.5	5	7	5
Performance (Out of 10)				
Test Scene (Lights)	6.3	6.1	5.6	4.9
Test Scene (Zoomed)	6	6	5.5	5.5
Flash Shot Quality	6	6	5	4.5
Macro Performance	6	6	5	5
Video Quality	6	6.5	5	8

done well. All the buttons have the same chunky feel as a D-SLR. It even comes with a mount for attaching external flash units. Another unique feature that makes this camera special is the ability to dump images as RAW and RAW JPEG.

As far as performance goes, it’s not as extraordinary as we might expect—considering it’s a feature-filled performance oriented camera with a mighty 20x optical zoom. The test scene showed a fair amount of grain, but there was still a good amount of detail without a lot of distortion. Colours were pretty neutral as well. The zoom is also very powerful and manages the exposure settings pretty well. Video quality is decent, but high-definition resolution should be a necessity in a camera such as this.



Olympus SP-570 UZ

Features such as face recognition, a calendar feature that sorts photos shot by the dates on the calendar. The expected priority modes for shutter speed, aperture as well as complete manual focusing are also present. There is a good amount of flexibility in the ISO range as well—50 to 3200 at maximum resolution. Image stability is extremely important in an ultra-zoom and the SP-570 UZ sports this for its humongous 20x optical zoom. It does a fair job too.

All these features and options don’t make the camera extremely complicated, but they are definitely a little more advanced than most simple point and shoot ones. This makes a good stop-gap solution before a full-fledged D-SLR. ■

rossi.fernandes@thinkdigit.com



What Should You Buy?



The Ultimate Performer

The **Canon PowerShot SX100 IS** is camera that is good at everything. It comes with a large 10x optical zoom and can handle macro shots rather well. The camera also has great colors and maintains detail in photos at all zoom levels. Other than its bulk, there isn’t anything major to complain about.



If you are looking for something a little cheaper and a little smaller, the **Canon PowerShot A720 IS** makes very good sense as well. At around Rs 3,000 less, the 6x performs equally well in quality and the camera has the similar set of manual controls as the SX100 IS.



Ultra Compact Portable Camera

The **Canon IXUS 85 IS** is a camera worthy of being in your pocket all the time. It is also one of the cameras that gives very good results without compromising on size. It is only a little bit more bulky than the Nikon COOLPIX S210 which is one of most compact cameras around. The Nikon S210 is also a little cheaper and can be your second choice if image detail and quality don’t mean everything to you.



Video Shooting

For video shooting, it’s best to have a camera that shoots HD resolutions. The **Samsung NV24HD** is the perfect camera for HD video shooting. With H.264 compression support, it saves tremendous space. The camera also supports SDHC cards, so you should be able to use large capacity cards for long periods of video recording. Along with the HD video recording capabilities, you also get an easy-to-use interface using the touch sensitive buttons. The price for the NV24HD is Rs 19,990.



If the NV24HD’s high price is a little too much, then the **Kodak M1330** could be an option to consider. It is priced at Rs 11,999. The video quality isn’t as top notch as the NV24HD, but it gets the job done.

A Camera With The Largest optical zoom



If you have no interest in the size of the camera itself, then the **Olympus SP-570 UZ** is the camera for you. The 20x optical zoom will be more than enough for most of your needs. The price is also extremely low, as compared to buying a professional D-SLR, and then buying a large zoom lens for it.



The other option available, if you want a large optical zoom lens camera, is the **Canon PowerShot SX100**. It only has 10x optical zoom, but is does a good job. It is a much simpler camera to use, and can act as an all purpose camera as well.

A Camera That Is Good value For Money



If your budget is around Rs 11,000, then the **Canon Power Shot A590 IS** makes excellent value for money. The camera is a lot cheaper than the Canon Power Shot SX100 and the A720 IS. At close to a third cheaper than the SX 100 IS, it still manages to give you most of the features, and almost the same performance.



If you are planning on spending more than Rs 16,000, then the choice is rather simple. The best performer of the class—the **Canon IXUS 85 IS** is also the best option for good value for money. It is the cheapest of the four cameras in its class.



The Cheapest Camera For Under Rs 10,000

The TECH-COM DSC-520 is a camera priced at just Rs 3,200. Although a little outdated and not as fancy or exotic as the more expensive cameras, it can still do a lot of what cameras priced close to Rs 10,000 can. We’ve also had to award the DSC-520 a *Best Buy* award for the under Rs 10,000 bracket, for this reason. If you have a budget of around Rs 8,000, then you should skip this camera and get the Canon PowerShot A470.